Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Robert Frost's "The Figure in the Doorway"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the speaker's characterization of both the "great gaunt figure" and "we who passed" him in Frost's "The Figure in the Doorway" include

alliteration,
anaphora,
characterization,
comparison (contrast),
couplet,
feminine rhyme,
iambic pentameter,
imagery,
irony,
litotes,
masculine rhyme,
repetition,
round character,
rhyme scheme,
rhythm,
theme, and
tone.

Robert Frost's "The Figure in the Doorway" is a fairly straightforward description of a recurring event (line 19 so implies), one that has given rise to a meditative reflection on what seems to be, in the final analysis, the superficial differences between someone in isolation and those who might, by virtue of traveling in company from one locus to another, consider themselves not bounded (or bound) by isolation.

The student should be able to draw—in summary—a description of the man in the doorway. The strong response, however, will note the round character developed through the speaker's observing the world beyond his doorway, being entertained by watching and, evidently, drawing his own conclusions about the lives of the people he sees framed by the windows of the train's passenger cars.

The young writer might recognize that the speaker is creating a vivid figure, one built on speculation—the train, no matter how many times it carries a passenger along the same track, offering but a glimpse of that figure in the doorway.

A stronger response to the essay prompt recognizes that much can be learned (perhaps ironically) about those on the train viewing the man in the doorway through the description of the man in the doorway himself. (Recall Faulkner's "Rose for Emily" and Chaucer's *General Prologue*, wherein we learn quite a bit about the narrators themselves through their descriptions of other characters).